- Buddha advocated ahimsa or non-violence.
- Buddha had rejected the caste system.

The Wheel of life – represents the Buddhist view of the world.

Buddhist Sangha

Buddha laid foundation for a missionary organization called Sangha, meaning 'association' for the propagation of his faith. The members were called bhikshus (monks). They led a life of austerity.

DO YOU KNOW?

Chaitya – A Buddhist shrine or a meditation hall.

Viharas – Monastries / living quarters for monks.

Stupas – Built over the remains of Buddha's body, they are monuments of great artistic value.

Buddhist Sects

Hinayana	Mahayana
Did not worship idols or images of Buddha.	Worshiped images of Buddha.
Practiced austerity.	Observed elaborate rituals
Believed that Salvation of the individual as its goal.	Believed that salvation of all beings as its objective
Used Prakrit language.	Used Sanskrit language
Hinayana is also known as Theravada. Spread to Sri Lanka, Myanmar (Burma) and South East Asian Countries.	Spread to Central Asia, Tibet, China and Japan where middle path was accepted.

Causes for the Spread of Buddhism

- Simplicity of the teachings of Buddha in local language appealed to people.
- Buddhism rejected elaborate religious customs whereas the practice of orthodox Vedic religion insisted on expensive rituals and sacrifices.
- Buddha's emphasis was on observance of Dhamma.
- Buddhist Sanghas played an important role in spreading the messages of Buddha.
- Royal patronage under Ashoka, Kanishka and Harsha also helped the causes of Buddhism.
- Viharas or the Buddhist monasteries became great centres of education. One such centre was Nalanda, where Hiuen Tsang, the Chinese pilgrim, studied for many years.

DO YOU KNOW?

Frescoes (paintings)

Frescoes on the ceilings and walls of the Ajanta caves in Aurangabad, Maharashtra – depict the Jataka Tales.



Middle path – It refers to neither indulging in extreme attachment to worldly pleasure nor committing severe penance.

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